

[Course: PHIL-0002] Course Information – Fall 2025

[Course: PHIL-0002] Course Links and Resources

Source: Official Course Pages

1. University College Course Page:

- Link: <https://universitycollege.tufts.edu/courses/browse/intro-philosophy>
- Contains official course description and general information

[Course: PHIL-0002] Fall 2025 Course Description

Source: Fall 2025 Course Catalog

The major types of philosophical thought and the central problems of philosophy are presented through study of some classic texts of the great philosophers. Offered each term. (May be used to satisfy the second half of the college writing requirement by students with credit for ENG 1.) Formerly PHIL 0001. Students may not receive credit for both PHIL 0001 and PHIL 0002.

[Course: PHIL-0002] Additional Course Description

Source: University College Course Page (<https://universitycollege.tufts.edu/courses/browse/intro-philosophy>)

Phil 0002 introduces students to problems in metaphysics and epistemology through close reading of several texts of Western Philosophy. Metaphysics is the study of the fundamental nature of reality. We will focus on the following metaphysical questions: What are we? Are we immaterial things, bodily things, some combination? Does God exist? Are our choices determined? Epistemology is the study of knowledge. How could we ever come to know the answers to these metaphysical questions? What is knowledge and how do we get it? Is knowledge attainable? Throughout our examination of these questions, we will also consider questions about values and what we should do. For example, what attitude should we take toward death? Is death the worst of evils? If we cannot be certain that some of our most fundamental beliefs are true, would it matter? If our choices are determined, then is there no such thing as good and bad, right and wrong? Philosophers have proposed thought provoking answers to these questions. We will read their works, consider their theories, and analyze and evaluate their arguments, with the objective of coming closer to our own answers, however tentative, to some of life's biggest questions.

[Course: PHIL-0002] Fall 2025 Course Sections

Source: Fall 2025 Course Catalog

1. Section 01-LEC (Class No. 80540):

- Instructor: Valentina Maria Urbanek

- Schedule: Tu, Th 9:00AM – 10:15AM
 - Location: Bromfield-Pearson, Room 003, Medford/Somerville
 - Credits: 3
 - Session: Regular
 - Status: Open (green circle)
 - Enrollment: 2 (12 seats available out of 14)
 - Wait List: 0 (5 spots available)
2. Section 05-LEC (Class No. 80563):
- Instructor: David A Denby
 - Schedule: Mo, We 3:00PM – 4:15PM
 - Location: Braker Hall, Room 222, Medford/Somerville
 - Credits: 3
 - Session: Regular
 - Status: Open (green circle)
 - Enrollment: 5 (9 seats available out of 14)
 - Reserve CAP Advising: 0 (10 spots available out of 10)
 - Wait List: 5 (0 spots available)
3. Section 09-LEC (Class No. 80545):
- Instructor: Michelle Mary Dyke
 - Schedule: Mo, We 4:30PM – 5:45PM
 - Location: Miner Hall, Room 112, Medford/Somerville
 - Credits: 3
 - Session: Regular
 - Status: Open (green circle)
 - Enrollment: 6 (8 seats available out of 14)
 - Wait List: 0 (5 spots available)
4. Section 10-LEC (Class No. 80546):
- Instructor: Merve Tapinc
 - Schedule: Tu, Th 9:00AM – 10:15AM
 - Location: Bromfield-Pearson, Room 006, Medford/Somerville
 - Credits: 3
 - Session: Regular
 - Status: Open (green circle)
 - Enrollment: 1 (13 seats available out of 14)
 - Wait List: 0 (5 spots available)

[Course: PHIL-0002] Fall 2025 Course Details
Source: Fall 2025 Course Catalog

1. Meeting Dates: 09/02/2025 – 12/08/2025
2. Class Attributes:
- BFA-Humanities
 - College Writing II
 - LA-Distribution-Humanities
 - SoE-HASS
 - SoE-HASS-Humanities

3. Career: AS&E Undergrad

4. Textbook: Textbook info (link available in registration system)

5. Grading: Graded

6. Instruction Mode: In Person

[Course: PHIL-0002] Fall 2025 Enrollment Requirements

Source: Fall 2025 Course Catalog

1. Prerequisites: None

2. Additional Course Information:

- Repeat for Credit: No
- Allow Multiple Enroll in Term: No
- Total Units Allowed: 3
- Total Completions Allowed: 1

[Course: PHIL-0002] Affiliated With

Source: University College Course Page

- School of Arts and Sciences

[Course: PHIL-0002] Student Reviews

Source: RateMyProfessor PHIL2 Reviews (2020-2024)

[Professor: Valentina Maria Urbanek] Reviews

Source: RateMyProfessor (<https://www.ratemyprofessors.com/professor/1951021>)

1. Instructor Overview:

- Overall: Mixed reviews, with several noting high grading standards and challenging coursework
- Average Quality Rating: 2.5/5.0 (based on 13 ratings)
- Average Difficulty Rating: 3.8/5.0
- Would Take Again: 37%

2. Student Feedback Highlights (Professor Urbanek):

- "Prof. Urbanek has unrealistically high standards for an intro class. Even 'very good!' or 'enjoyed your essay' will only get you a B+. Discussions are one-sided, with few students participating, and she doesn't encourage more." (Dec 2024)
- "Her lectures are more summaries than explanations, so you're better off focusing on rereading the materials." (Dec 2024)
- "She does not give good feedback on essays. She does not give good grades. It feels as if she does not want us to succeed." (Dec 2024)
- "Her lectures make it easier to understand the difficult readings and they are decently interesting. She's a tough grader so you'll have

to put the work in to get a B+/A-." (Dec 2023)

- "Grade is made up of five papers, including one rewrite." (Dec 2023)

3. Common Tags (Professor Urbanek):

- "TOUGH GRADER" (mentioned consistently across reviews)
- "GET READY TO READ"
- "LECTURE HEAVY"

4. Study Recommendations (Professor Urbanek's Class):

- Focus on thoroughly understanding the reading materials
- Start papers early and consider using writing tutors
- Participation in discussions is important but not always encouraged
- Be prepared for rigorous grading standards

[Professor: David A Denby] Reviews

No reviews available from RateMyProfessor.

[Professor: Michelle Mary Dyke] Reviews

No reviews available from RateMyProfessor.

[Professor: Merve Tapinc] Reviews

No reviews available from RateMyProfessor.

[Professor: Ian Blaustein] Reviews

Source: RateMyProfessor (<https://www.ratemyprofessors.com/professor/2446044>)

1. Instructor Overview:

- Overall: Highly positive reviews
- Average Quality Rating: 4.6/5.0 (based on 21 ratings)
- Average Difficulty Rating: 2.5/5.0
- Would Take Again: 86%

2. Student Feedback Highlights (Professor Blaustein):

- "Great professor. A bit boring and can be awkward but it doesn't matter, he tries to be funny and is very genuine. Essays are easy to write and he asks for outline, draft, etc. before submission so you'll have a lot of time to think." (Nov 2024)

- "He is one of the best professors I've had in my life. A kind, interesting human being, and absolutely a wonderful lecturer. He respects every students in his class and tries his best to let everyone engaged." (Apr 2023)

- "This prof had a very laidback approach to class that made it very engaging. Student discussion shined through, and he was great at facilitating discussion without letting his opinion be known." (Sep 2022)

- "Generally, one of the best lecturers/instructors I have met at Tufts -- super engaging class discussions and very kind and

inclusive." (May 2022)

- "Ian is legitimately one of the most incredible teachers I have ever had. If you have the opportunity to take one of his classes, you have to." (Jan 2020)

- "One of my favorite professors at Tufts so far! Ian is really thoughtful about how he structures the class -- is always open to student input -- and fosters awesome discussions among students." (Dec 2018)

3. Common Tags (Professor Blaustein):

- "CARING" (mentioned consistently across reviews)
- "PARTICIPATION MATTERS"
- "AMAZING LECTURES"
- "GIVES GOOD FEEDBACK"
- "INSPIRATIONAL"

4. Study Recommendations (Professor Blaustein's Class):

- Be prepared to participate in discussions
- Take advantage of his feedback process for essays
- Readings can be substantial but manageable
- The class is what you make of it - engagement leads to better experience
- Works well for students looking to fulfill English credit requirements

Last Updated: Based on Fall 2025 Course Catalog and University College Course Page (<https://universitycollege.tufts.edu/courses/browse/intro-philosophy>) with student reviews from RateMyProfessor

Data updated on April 20, 2025.